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THE PARENT GUIDE SERIES



VOLUME 6 · FREE STARTER GUIDE

Adult SSDI & SSI

A Free Starter Guide to Applying for Disability Benefits as an Adult

Clear guidance for the benefits journey

anchorandableco.com

Written from my own experience. SSDI & SSI are federal — the rules are the same in every state.

A note from Beth

I'm Beth. Before I was the mom writing guides about SSI for kids, I was an adult who couldn't keep working, filing my own disability claim — and I made every beginner's mistake there is, because nobody hands you the playbook.

This free starter guide is the first page of that playbook: the essentials for applying for SSDI or SSI as an adult, in plain language. **SSDI and SSI are federal programs — the rules are the same in every state.** Where this touches state programs, it's California's, the system I know from my own claim.

The full guide (Volume 6, on anchorandableco.com) goes step by step through all of it. This starter covers what you need to begin — because beginning *now* is the whole ballgame.

The two doors, in one minute

SSDI is insurance you paid for through work. It needs **work credits** (in 2026, one credit per $1,890 of covered earnings, four a year max), pays based on your earnings record, has **no limit on savings**, and brings Medicare after a waiting period.

SSI is need-based — no work history required. It pays up to **$994 a month in 2026** (most states add a supplement; California adds roughly $240), and it has a hard **resource limit: $2,000** for an individual. In California it brings Medi-Cal automatically.

Both use the **same medical test**: you must be unable to do substantial work — in 2026, earning over **$1,690 a month** counts as substantial — because of a condition expected to last at least 12 months. Many people qualify for **both**. Apply for both.

Over $2,000 in the bank? A **CalABLE** account can hold up to $100,000 that doesn't count against SSI's limit (disability onset before age 46). That's Volume 4 of this series — and it can be the difference between eligible and denied.

Start the clock — today

Approval can take **one to two years**. The clock starts the day you file — not the day you got sick. So:

File first, perfect later. File your initial application *before* you have all the extra documents. You can always add them later — even the following week. Just get your start date in the books today.

The online application asks for **information, not documents**. Bare bones:

- Name, Social Security number, date and place of birth, address, phone
- Spouse and children details (this is how extra family benefits get found)
- When you stopped working, recent earnings, jobs from the last 5 years
- Your conditions, your main doctors and clinics with approximate dates, your medications
- Bank account and routing numbers for direct deposit
- For SSI: living arrangement, income, bank balances, vehicles, property

Apply at **ssa.gov/apply** or **1-800-772-1213**. In California, file for **State Disability (EDD)** the same week — the two clocks are independent, and both should be running.

Five habits that decide cases

Cases are decided on the file — on what your paper says about what you can and cannot do. These five habits build that file:

1. **Keep a symptom journal.** Daily notes: symptoms, what you couldn't do, bad days, side effects — and *every medication change and why*. If a symptom happened even once — one fall, one ER visit, one day you couldn't get out of bed — it goes in. Decision-makers decide on function, and memory fades.

2. **Check the DSM-5.** If yours is a mental-health condition, read your diagnosis's official criteria and make sure your chart documents *your* symptoms in those words. What's not in your chart doesn't exist to Social Security.

3. **Gather your work-life evidence.** Write-ups, bad reviews, attendance records from past jobs are objective proof your disability was costing you at work. And know this: missing more than about **two days of work a month** is more than employers tolerate — hearing experts say so themselves.

4. **Pre-write your doctor's letter.** Busy providers won't draft from a blank page. Write the facts and functional limits yourself; let your doctor review, correct, add, and sign as their own. Minutes for them — and it actually gets submitted.

5. **Work your case weekly.** Learn your examiner's name. Check in every week or so, always bringing something new. Keep sending documents as they happen — and call to confirm they were received. Never assume.

One warning: do not collect **unemployment** while claiming disability. Unemployment certifies you're able and available for work — the opposite of your claim, and judges ask about it by name. State disability is the bridge; unemployment is a trap.

Your first-week checklist

- ☐ Check your work credits at ssa.gov/myaccount
- ☐ Start the symptom journal
- ☐ List your providers, medications, and last-15-years jobs
- ☐ Request your personnel file (write-ups, attendance) from past employers
- ☐ Over $2,000 saved and applying for SSI? Open a CalABLE account first
- ☐ File SSDI + SSI — start date in the books
- ☐ California: file EDD State Disability the same week
- ☐ Start a send log: every document, the date, who confirmed receipt

What the full guide adds

The complete **Adult SSDI & SSI** guide (Volume 6, $9) walks the whole road: the five questions Social Security actually asks · work credits and the date-last-insured trap · working while you apply · the full evidence playbook · surviving the wait, including California SDI's re-certifications (I drew the full year — it's how we kept a roof overhead until SSDI came through) · what approval pays, including benefits for your children · denials and the hearing · hiring a representative on contingency — they don't get paid unless you win · a complete start checklist · and a full resources page, websites and phone numbers included.

Get it at **anchorandableco.com** or **anchorable.gumroad.com/l/adult-ssdi-ssi**.

Questions along the way? I'm a resource too: **anchorandableco@gmail.com** · **@anchorandableco**. Guidance from lived experience — I'm not an attorney or an accredited representative, and this is education, not advice about your specific case. Figures are 2026 amounts from the Social Security Administration; confirm current

numbers at ssa.gov.